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Abstract

The rising prevalence of dissociative phenomena among younger generations is a clinical fact. What produces it remains theoretically unaddressed. This paper argues that what produces this prevalence is structural: the contemporary subject undergoes a *double expropriation*, whose two terms, while analytically distinct, are causally entangled. The first is structural and external: the classical Marxian alienation from the product of labour, reconfigured under post-Fordist capitalism into the expropriation of subjectivity itself (creativity, affect, and personal identity conscripted as productive resources), and extended, through Fisher's concept of capitalist realism, into the cultural foreclosure of imaginative alternatives. The second is psychological and internal: an alienation from the self, enacted through the virtual sphere, psychoactive substances, and dissociative symptomatology. This second-order alienation is not reducible to individual pathology. It is a structural response: the psyche's adaptation to a social order that simultaneously produces conditions of non-belonging and offers hyperreal substitutes in their place. Drawing on Debord's account of spectacular culture, Baudrillard's theory of simulacra, and Wallace's diagnosis of entertainment as anesthesia, this paper develops the concept of *third-person subjectivity*: the habitual, structural, and in its most acute forms clinical positioning of the subject as spectator rather than inhabitant of his own experience. Depersonalization disorder is proposed as the symbolic illness of our epoch: not the most statistically prevalent condition, but the most culturally legible, as the pathological intensification of a mode of being the broader culture actively normalizes. Generation Z is examined as the paradigmatic case. The clinical and political implications of reading dissociation structurally, rather than as individual failure, are developed in the conclusion.

Keywords: alienation, dissociation, third-person subjectivity, capitalist realism, hyperreality, Generation Z, spectacular culture, digital capitalism

Public Significance Statement: The growing prevalence of dissociation among younger generations is a clinical fact, but what produces it has remained theoretically unexplained. This article argues that it is a structural response to a double alienation, external, from the conditions of contemporary capitalism, and internal, from one's own experience. It proposes third-person subjectivity, the habit of observing rather than inhabiting one's own life, as its defining form.

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1. Introduction

In 1844, Marx identified a condition that would come to define the modern subject's relation to the world: the worker, stripped of ownership over the product of labour, finds the external world increasingly alien, an objective force that stands over and against him. This *Entfremdung*, or estrangement, was not merely an economic inconvenience but an ontological displacement: the subject, expropriated from what he produces, ceases to recognize himself in the world he inhabits. The social machinery of capital generates, as its structural byproduct, a human being who does not belong.

Nearly two centuries later, the diagnosis retains its analytical force, but the phenomenon has deepened and migrated. The contemporary subject, particularly among the generations born after 1995, does not merely fail to recognize himself in the products of his labour or in the institutions that organize his life. He increasingly fails to recognize himself in himself. Where Marx described an alienation directed outward (the subject estranged from the object), we are witnessing an alienation directed inward: the subject estranged from his own experience, his own continuity, his own interiority. Psychological dissociation, clinically defined as a disruption in the normally integrated functions of consciousness, memory, identity, and perception, has become, this paper argues, the symbolic illness of our time: not because it is simply more prevalent, but because it has become structurally legible as a form of adaptation to conditions that make coherent selfhood increasingly difficult to sustain.

This paper proposes a theoretical framework for understanding this shift. The central argument is as follows: the contemporary subject undergoes a *double expropriation*. The first is structural

and external: the classical Marxian alienation, updated through the lens of late capitalism as described by Boltanski and Chiapello (2005) and extended by Fisher's (2009) concept of *capitalist realism*, a cultural condition in which the imaginative horizon of social alternatives has significantly narrowed. The second is psychological and internal: an alienation from the self, enacted through and sustained by the virtual sphere, psychoactive substances, and dissociative symptomatology. This second-order alienation is not, it is contended here, a mere individual pathology or a random epidemiological trend. It is a *structural response*: the psyche's adaptation to a social order that simultaneously produces conditions of non-belonging and offers hyperreal substitutes in their place.

The concept of hyperreality is central to this argument. Baudrillard (1981/1994) argued that contemporary consumer society no longer produces representations of reality but *simulacra*: signs that refer not to any underlying real but only to other signs, generating a self-referential condition he termed hyperreality. Where Debord (1967) had described the spectacle as the inversion of lived experience, in which what is lived becomes mere representation, Baudrillard extended this analysis: in the society of the simulacrum, the boundary between life and representation becomes increasingly indeterminate. This logic is extended here into the domain of subjectivity: just as the external world tends toward hyperreality, a screen of signs detached from referents, so too, under certain conditions, does the inner world. The dissociated self is, in this reading, a subject who has internalized the logic of the simulacrum: a self that produces the appearance of continuity without its experiential substance.

This argument has particular relevance with respect to Generations Z and post-Z, those born roughly between 1997 and the early 2010s. These cohorts have come of age within the architecture of digital platforms, where socialization, identity formation, labour, and leisure increasingly occur within environments structured around engagement, visibility, and performance. They are, as Turkle (2011) observed, *alone together*: densely connected at the level of signal, yet reporting high degrees of isolation at the level of experience. The epidemiological data on mental health in these generations, marked by notable increases in anxiety, depression,

and dissociative phenomena, are not incidental. They are symptoms of structural conditions, and they warrant serious theoretical attention alongside clinical analysis.

The theoretical contribution of this paper is threefold. First, it rehabilitates and extends the Marxian concept of alienation beyond its classical economic frame, articulating it as a condition that operates simultaneously at structural and psychological levels. Second, it proposes the concept of *second-order alienation*, that is, alienation from the self, as a philosophically distinct but causally related phenomenon, one that existing literature has addressed primarily in clinical terms without sufficient attention to its social determinants. Third, it reads dissociation not as a failure of the individual psyche but as a *culturally intelligible response* to conditions that make stable selfhood structurally precarious: a world in which belonging has been progressively replaced by connectivity, experience by content, and identity by performance.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 reconstructs the classical account of alienation and its contemporary elaborations. Section 3 traces the passage from Debord's spectacle to Baudrillard's simulacrum, establishing the theoretical ground for understanding virtual space as a domain of second-order alienation. Section 4 develops the concept of psychological dissociation as structural symptom, drawing on Fisher, Sennett, and the clinical literature. Section 5 examines Generation Z as the paradigmatic case. Section 6 synthesizes these threads into a unified theoretical framework. Section 7 concludes with reflections on the political and clinical implications of reading dissociation structurally rather than individually.

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2. The First Alienation: Marx and the Structural Dispossession

The theoretical foundation of this argument rests on Marx's account of alienation as developed in the *Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844*. For Marx, alienation (*Entfremdung*) names a specific relational distortion: the worker, expropriated from the product of his labour, finds the external world increasingly alien, an objective force that confronts him as something not his own. Crucially, this estrangement is not merely economic but existential: it extends from the product to the act of production, from the act of production to the worker's relation to himself

and to other human beings. Alienation, in Marx's account, is total: it reorganizes the entire field of the subject's relations to world, to others, and to self.

For the purposes of this argument, Jaeggi's (2014) reformulation of this concept is particularly productive. Rather than grounding alienation in a fixed human essence, Jaeggi understands it as a *failure of appropriation*: an inability to make one's own life and activity genuinely one's own. This reformulation preserves the normative force of the concept while freeing it from the metaphysical commitments that rendered earlier humanist readings vulnerable to critique. Alienation, on this account, is not about what humans essentially are, but about a specific form of failed relation, one that is historically produced and therefore historically variable.

It should be noted that this metaphysical fixity is less a feature of Marx's own 1844 text than of certain humanist readings of it. Already in the Manuscripts, Marx historicizes the human essence: the forming of the five senses, he writes, is a labour of the entire history of the world, situating the sensuous powers of the species-being as a historically determined product rather than a fixed natural given. Jaeggi's reformulation thus extends a movement already latent in Marx rather than correcting a metaphysical error in him.

This historical variability is precisely what Boltanski and Chiapello (2005) illuminate in their analysis of late capitalism. Their central argument is that capitalism, in each of its historical phases, generates what they term a *spirit*: an ideological apparatus that responds to three fundamental questions: why engage in the capitalist process? How to secure stability for oneself and one's children? And how to justify participation in capitalism in terms of the common good? The postwar decades represented a configuration of this spirit in which the promise of security was genuinely credible: pension systems, educational credentials, regularized career trajectories, and robust welfare institutions collectively constituted what might be called a *compensatory apparatus*, a set of social mechanisms that partially offset the alienation of labour by offering belonging, continuity, and a horizon of progress.

This compensatory apparatus began to erode in the 1970s, striking first at the margins: women, immigrants, the young without credentials, while the dirigiste elites interpreted this as inevitable

necessity rather than structural failure. By the time the erosion reached the centre, the ideological resources to narrate it as temporary had been exhausted. Boltanski and Chiapello identify the result as a crisis of the spirit of capitalism itself: a condition of growing disorientation in which capitalism can no longer provide convincing answers to its own constitutive questions. No valid substitute for the trust in progress has been found.

The post-Fordist transformation of labour intervened with a paradoxical response. Where industrial capitalism expropriated the worker's time and physical labour, the new spirit of capitalism, organized around flexibility, project-based work, and network participation, expropriates subjectivity itself: creativity, affect, social relations, and personal identity become productive resources. And crucially, this transformation was accomplished in part by absorbing the very critiques levelled at the rigidity and hierarchy of industrial capitalism. The demand for autonomy, authenticity, and liberation from bureaucratic hierarchy, what Boltanski and Chiapello term the *artistic critique* of the 1960s and 1970s, was incorporated into the new management ideology as flexibility, self-realization, and creative freedom. The consequence is a more thoroughgoing form of expropriation: when the self itself becomes a productive resource, there is no remainder of interiority that escapes the logic of capital. The subject has been convinced to expropriate himself in the name of freedom.

Fisher's (2009) concept of *capitalist realism* extends this analysis into the cultural domain: the progressive foreclosure of imaginative alternatives produces a subject who understands his condition but experiences himself as structurally incapable of transforming it. What this trajectory describes, in sum, is a progressive erosion of belonging: to the world of labour, to the institutions that organize social life, to any collective horizon of meaning. The contemporary subject inhabits a world in which the conditions for stable, socially embedded selfhood have been systematically undermined, and in which the ideological resources to narrate this condition as temporary have been exhausted. It is this condition, of non-belonging without compensatory apparatus, that generates the pressure to which, as the following sections argue, second-order alienation responds.

3. The Spectacle and the Virtual: From Debord to Baudrillard

The theoretical passage from structural alienation to its psychological internalization requires an intermediate step: an account of how the external world, the world of images, representations, and mediated experience, came to substitute for, and eventually displace, lived reality itself. This passage is traced across three bodies of work that, taken together, constitute a genealogy of the contemporary subject's estrangement from experience: Guy Debord's *The Society of the Spectacle* (1967), Jean Baudrillard's *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981), and the critical and literary writings of David Foster Wallace.

Debord's foundational proposition is deceptively simple: all of life in societies where modern conditions of production prevail presents itself as an immense accumulation of spectacles. By *spectacle*, Debord does not mean simply the proliferation of images, though this is part of it. He means something more fundamental: a social relation between people mediated by images. The connection to Marx is deliberate and precise. Where classical alienation expropriated the worker from the product of his labour, spectacular alienation expropriates the subject from the totality of his experience. Debord's key formulation is that everything directly lived has moved away into representation: not that we watch life instead of living it, but that the form of social life itself has become spectacular, so that desires, relations, and identities are structured through representations rather than through direct experience.

Particularly significant for this argument is what Debord identifies, in theses 30 and 33, as the structure of thirdness implicit in spectacular alienation. The spectator finds that his own gestures are no longer his own but belong to another who represents them to him. The subject does not recognize himself in his own activity: he contemplates it from a position of exteriority, as if it belonged to someone else. As Lukács had already noted in his analysis of reification, the increasing rationalization of the productive process transforms the worker's activity from active engagement into passive contemplation. The subject becomes a spectator of his own life. This is the phenomenological core of what the following sections develop as third-person subjectivity.

What Debord diagnosed as tendency, Baudrillard radicalized into condition. Writing fifteen years later, Baudrillard argued that the Debordian spectacle still presupposed a real beneath the representation, a lived experience behind the image. For Baudrillard, this presupposition had become untenable. Contemporary society does not merely represent reality through images; it *replaces* reality with simulacra: copies without originals, signs that refer not to any underlying real but only to other signs. The result is what Baudrillard terms *hyperreality*: a condition in which the distinction between the real and its representation collapses entirely, not because representation has become more faithful to the real, but because the real has been absorbed into the representational order. Baudrillard organizes this process around four successive stages of the image, from faithful reflection, through distortion, through the masking of absence, to the pure simulacrum that bears no relation to any reality whatsoever.

This framework has acquired a literal precision that Baudrillard himself could not have anticipated. The proliferation of AI-generated images and videos, synthetic media indistinguishable from recorded reality, represents the logical terminus of the simulacral order: not a copy that passes itself off as an original, but a production that never had an original to begin with. Reality is not destroyed; it is rendered structurally irrelevant. When a face, a voice, a scene can be generated with full photographic fidelity from statistical patterns alone, the Baudrillardian fourth stage ceases to be a philosophical provocation and becomes a technical condition.

It is within this context that the contemporary explosion of serialized television and streaming content assumes its theoretical significance. Serial drama has become the art form of our epoch, not merely as entertainment, but as the primary cultural site in which forms of life are elaborated, distributed, and consumed daily. What distinguishes the contemporary streaming landscape from earlier mass media is not simply quantity but structure: an effectively infinite, algorithmically personalized catalogue of characters, relationships, social worlds, and modes of being, available continuously and integrated into the rhythms of everyday life. Unlike cinema, an event spatially and temporally separated from ordinary existence, serialized television inhabits the domestic

space of daily life, colonizing the time between production and sleep. The subject does not leave his life to watch a story; the story enters his life, rhythms it, and gradually substitutes for it a parallel narrative world populated by characters followed for years, whose lives unfold in near-real time alongside his own. He does not follow a plot: he inhabits, in third person, an alternative world.

It is here that David Foster Wallace's critical diagnosis becomes indispensable. In his 1993 essay "E Unibus Pluram: Television and U.S. Fiction," Wallace identified with remarkable precision the subjective consequences of inhabiting a world saturated with representations of life. His central insight was not merely that television distracts from lived experience but that sustained immersion in representational environments produces a specific mode of self-relation: ironic, distanced, perpetually observing. The subject formed within a representational environment does not experience his own life directly: he watches it, comments on it, maintains a reflexive distance from it. This ironic distance is not a defense mechanism adopted by individuals; it is a cultural habitus, a collectively produced form of self-relation in which immediacy has become structurally inaccessible.

The deeper argument, elaborated across Wallace's fiction and most fully realized in *Infinite Jest* (1996), is that entertainment in its contemporary form functions as anesthesia, not escapism in the traditional sense, but a systematic substitution of experience with something more manageable, more pleasurable, less demanding. To live continuously entertained is, in Wallace's formulation, another way of not living: a soft dissociation from the weight of unmediated existence.

The convergence of these frameworks, Debord's substitution of lived experience, Baudrillard's dissolution of the real into simulacra, and Wallace's account of entertainment as anesthesia, points toward an emergent structural tendency that the following sections develop theoretically: the organization of contemporary cultural life around what this paper terms *third-person subjectivity*. Across the dominant forms of the contemporary entertainment ecosystem, serialized television, pornography, gaming, social media, reaction content, a single structural principle

recurs: the subject is positioned as spectator rather than agent, as observer rather than inhabitant, of experience. This positioning is not incidental to these forms but constitutive of them. And it is not merely a cultural style: it is the external face of a psychological demand generated by a subject overwhelmed by stimuli and actively, if not always consciously, seeking the relief of anesthetic distance. It is to the psychological structure of that demand that the next section turns.

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4. The Second Alienation: Psychological Dissociation as Structural Symptom

The fifth edition of the *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders* (DSM-5; American Psychiatric Association, 2013) defines dissociative disorders as conditions characterized by a disruption of and/or discontinuity in the normal integration of consciousness, memory, identity, emotion, perception, behavior, and sense of self. Three categories are of particular relevance to this argument. Depersonalization/Derealization Disorder involves persistent or recurrent experiences of feeling detached from one's mental processes or body, or of being an outside observer of one's thoughts, feelings, sensations, and actions, a condition that is, at the phenomenological level, precisely what has been described here as third-person subjectivity. Dissociative Amnesia involves an inability to recall autobiographical information, disrupting the continuity of the self-narrative that ordinarily constitutes personal identity over time. The category of Unspecified Dissociative Disorder, the nosographic residual, is perhaps the most theoretically significant: it names what the classificatory system recognizes as dissociative without being able to fully contain it, implicitly acknowledging that the phenomenon exceeds its own taxonomy.

These classifications are not contested here, nor is the clinical reality they describe dissolved. Dissociative disorders are genuine psychological conditions with significant consequences for the individuals who experience them, and they require clinical attention and treatment. The argument operates at a different level of analysis. When a clinical phenomenon shows markedly increasing prevalence within a specific generational cohort, as the epidemiological data on dissociative and related symptoms among Generation Z consistently indicate, the clinical

question of what the disorder is and how it should be treated must be supplemented by a structural question: why this phenomenon, why now, and why this generation? The clinician addresses the individual; the theorist addresses the condition of possibility.

This methodological move requires a preliminary clarification. The rising prevalence of dissociative phenomena does not occur in isolation. It is accompanied, and in many respects preceded, by an equally significant rise in anxiety disorders, which now represent the most common form of psychological distress among younger generations. The relationship between anxiety and dissociation is not incidental: they are, this paper argues, complementary responses to the same structural condition, operating at opposite poles of a single adaptive spectrum. Anxiety is the response of a subject who remains hyperactivated in the face of unmanageable uncertainty, a subject who cannot disengage from a reality experienced as threatening and unpredictable. Dissociation is the response of a subject who disengages entirely, who manages the same unbearable uncertainty by retreating from direct experience into spectatorial distance. Clinically, the link between anxiety and intolerance of uncertainty is now so well established as to constitute a near-definitional relationship: anxiety, in its contemporary clinical understanding, is largely indistinguishable from the inability to tolerate not-knowing. The culture of precarity that Boltanski and Chiapello (2005) describe, generalized across economic, relational, and familial dimensions, produces, at the level of individual psychology, precisely this intolerance. Anxiety and dissociation are not rival pathologies but twin responses: one hyperactivates, the other anesthetizes; one stays too close to reality, the other retreats too far. Both are structurally produced by the same condition of radical uncertainty without compensatory apparatus.

Fisher (2009) argued that mental health is not a politically neutral domain, that the forms pathology takes in a given historical moment are not arbitrary but symptomatic. Depression and anxiety, in Fisher's account, are not merely individual misfortunes but characteristic expressions of a social order that produces chronic stress, radical uncertainty, and the systematic erosion of collective frameworks for meaning-making. This logic is extended here to dissociation: its rising prevalence is not incidental but symptomatic, a signal, at the level of individual psychology, of

structural conditions that make coherent, continuous, first-person selfhood increasingly difficult to sustain.

This way of reading a pathology as the symbolic condensation of a historical moment is not new; it has a genealogy of its own. Without proposing a rigid one-to-one correspondence, one can trace a succession of symbolic illnesses, each giving clinical form to the dominant tensions of its epoch. The nineteenth century had its neurasthenia, the nervous exhaustion of industrial modernity, and, in the consulting rooms of fin-de-siecle Vienna, the hysteria of bourgeois women that Freud and Breuer took as their point of departure, a symptom in which the sexual and social constraints of the age became legible on the body. The first half of the twentieth century, scarred by two World Wars, was marked less by the trauma of the returning soldier than by a more diffuse and collective condition: the mourning of entire societies for their dead. It is the depressive tonality of the survivor rather than the veteran that defines the epoch, a whole civilian population in grief, for which Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) furnished the conceptual grammar, distinguishing the labour of mourning from the melancholia in which loss, unresolved, turns inward and settles into a lasting depressive condition. The decades following 2001 can be read, in turn, as the age of anxiety: an epoch of permanent uncertainty, precarity, and threat, in which anxiety became the emblematic form of contemporary distress. It is precisely out of this anxious configuration that dissociation emerges as its successor and its escape: where anxiety keeps the subject hyperactivated before an unbearable reality, dissociation offers retreat from it. The argument advanced here thus does not invent the notion of a symbolic illness ex nihilo but extends an established series: depersonalization is proposed as the symbolic illness of digital, hyperreal capitalism, the point at which its dissociative structure is condensed into a form of suffering. Dissociation, above all, is an escape.

The argument advanced here is more specific than a claim about linear cultural causation. The relationship between overstimulation, the demand for dissociative states, and the consumption of technologies that facilitate them is not sequential but systemic: a field of non-linear interactions in which each element co-determines the others without a single identifiable point of origin or a

privileged causal direction. Digital capitalism produces an unprecedented density of stimuli; this density generates, in the subjects it immerses, a functional demand for anesthetic distance from the intensity of direct experience; the entertainment ecosystem responds to and amplifies this demand through cultural forms, serialized television, pornography, gaming, social media, reaction content, whose primary psychological function, whatever their explicit content, is to facilitate the subject's retreat from first-person experience into the spectatorial distance of the third person; and this retreat, sustained over time, further reduces the subject's tolerance for unmediated experience, intensifying the original condition. Whether this process operates consciously or unconsciously is, for these purposes, irrelevant: a structural function is being described, not a subjective intention.

The inclusion of psychoactive substances in this framework requires specification. Not all substances function as technologies of dissociation in the same way. Alcohol produces alteration through intense physical involvement: the body is implicated, control is lost somatically, the experience is one of heightened rather than reduced physical presence, even if cognitively distorted. Cannabis operates differently: it produces precisely the structure of managed distance that characterizes third-person subjectivity, a slowing and distancing of cognitive processes, a sense of observing one's own mind from the outside, a softening of the boundary between self and representation. It combines naturally with the other technologies of dissociation: cannabis is characteristically consumed while watching serialized television, gaming, or scrolling algorithmically curated content, potentiating rather than disrupting the spectatorial mode. The epidemiological shift observable in Generation Z, drinking less alcohol while consuming more cannabis than preceding generations, is, in this framework, not coincidental. It reflects a generational preference for the dissociative substance over the somatic one: a pharmacological expression of the broader structural preference for anesthetic distance over embodied presence.

This structural reading does not exclude more proximate explanations. The generational shift toward cannabis is clearly over-determined: progressive legalization across many U.S. states and other jurisdictions, declining stigma, and the normalization of both medicinal and recreational

use across social strata, and not only among Generation Z, have all increased its availability and acceptability. Yet these developments are not external to the argument advanced here; they are themselves signs of the times. That a culture increasingly oriented toward anesthetic distance should also progressively normalize, legalize, and destigmatize the very substance that most efficiently produces such distance is not a competing explanation but a further expression of the same structural tendency. The social diffusion of cannabis and the subjective preference for it are two faces of a single movement.

Twenge's (2017) data on the developmental deceleration of Generation Z adds a further dimension. A generation exposed earlier than any previous cohort to adult stimuli through digital platforms is simultaneously delaying the actual assumption of adult roles and responsibilities to an unprecedented degree. This is not contradiction but consequence: early and intense exposure to represented adult experience does not accelerate development but substitutes for it. The subject who has consumed thousands of hours of represented intimacy, represented conflict, represented achievement, and represented identity before the age of sixteen has not thereby accumulated experience: he has accumulated representations that stand in the place of experience, deferring rather than enabling the development of the capacities that come only through direct engagement with reality.

Sennett's (1998) analysis of the corrosion of character under conditions of flexible capitalism provides a complementary perspective. The demand for flexibility, for a self that is always adaptable, always provisional, never committed to any single identity or trajectory, produces a specific form of psychological fragmentation: the inability to construct a coherent narrative of one's own life. The self becomes episodic rather than continuous, defined by a series of disconnected performances rather than by an integrated identity that persists through time. The clinically dissociated subject and the flexibly fragmented subject of post-Fordist capitalism share a common architecture, one produced at the extreme end of a continuum that the broader culture actively normalizes.

This structural reading of psychiatric diagnosis has an important precedent in Ehrenberg's (1998/2010) analysis of depression as the weariness of being oneself. For Ehrenberg, depression became the emblematic pathology of the late twentieth century because it condensed the tensions of a social order that had replaced discipline and prohibition with the imperative of autonomy and self-realization: the subject, commanded to be fully and continuously himself, collapses under the weight of a demand that admits no rest. The framework proposed here stands in direct kinship with this analysis, and can be specified by contrast with it. If depression is the illness of the subject who must be himself and fails, dissociation is the illness of the subject who withdraws from the demand of first-person selfhood altogether. Where Ehrenberg's depressive subject exhausts himself in the effort of autonomous self-realization, the dissociative subject retreats from the first person into the managed distance of the third. Depersonalization occupies, within the hyperreal and spectacular configuration analyzed here, the emblematic position that depression occupied within an order organized around responsibility, performance, and the demand for autonomous self-realization: not its replacement, but its successor under altered structural conditions.

It is this normalization that constitutes the most significant theoretical claim of this section. Dissociation, in its subclinical forms, has become a culturally sanctioned and technologically facilitated mode of being. The subject who watches rather than lives, who observes rather than acts, who consumes representations of experience rather than inhabiting experience directly: this subject is not aberrant. He is the product of an environment systematically organized around the production of spectatorial distance. The pathological and the normal exist on a continuum, and what the DSM-5 identifies at the extreme end of that continuum as disorder is, at its subclinical base, the dominant mode of contemporary subjectivity. To recognize this is not to deny the reality of clinical dissociation: it is to ask what it means that the culture has moved, structurally and systematically, in the direction of the pathological pole.

5. Generation Z as Paradigmatic Case

The theoretical framework developed in the preceding sections finds its most concentrated empirical expression in the generations born after 1995, those who have come of age entirely within the architecture of digital capitalism, for whom the spectacularization of experience and the technologies of dissociation are not historical developments but constitutive conditions of subjectivity. Generation Z is not merely an illustration of this argument: it is its paradigmatic case, the cohort in which the structural tendencies identified here achieve their most legible and most acute form.

To understand why, however, it is necessary to situate Generation Z within a longer historical trajectory. The structural conditions that produce second-order alienation did not emerge overnight. Their prehistory runs through the postwar decades of compensatory security, pension systems, career progression, educational credentials, welfare institutions, that partially offset the alienation of labour by offering belonging, continuity, and a credible horizon of progress. That compensatory apparatus began to erode in the 1970s, striking first at the margins: women, immigrants, the young without credentials. By the time the erosion reached the centre, the ideological resources to narrate it as temporary had been exhausted. The cultural response to this collapse was not immediate. It took shape gradually, through the aesthetic and pharmacological dissidences of those who first fell outside the system. The grunge culture of the 1990s, its sonic aesthetics of disillusionment, its deliberate abjection, its ironic distance from the promises of progress, constitutes the first mass cultural expression of this collapse: a generation that had been promised the compensatory apparatus and found it unavailable, reaching for artificial paradises and spectatorial irony as substitutes. The non-integrated subjects of the 1980s, those first struck by deindustrialization, precarity, and the retreat of welfare, had already begun this exodus toward dissociative responses, chemical and cultural. The 1990s generalized it aesthetically. The 2000s digitized it. Generation Z inherited it as infrastructure.

The epidemiological evidence for this generational shift is substantial and consistent across independent datasets. Twenge et al. (2018) documented significant increases in depressive

symptoms, suicide-related outcomes, and suicide rates among U.S. adolescents after 2010, linking these trends to increased new media screen time. In a subsequent review, Twenge (2020) confirmed that increases in depression, self-harm, and suicide among U.S. adolescents after 2012 are concurrent with increases in digital media use, with large national studies consistently documenting these trends across the 2000s and 2010s. A longitudinal time-lag study published in the *Journal of Youth and Adolescence* found direct support for higher depressive symptoms, suicide ideation, and anxiety among more recent adolescent cohorts compared to past cohorts, confirming that Generation Z is experiencing elevated rates of internalizing mental health problems relative to preceding generations at equivalent life stages (Borg et al., 2024). At the population level, Collier Villaume et al. (2023), analyzing over three million responses in *JAMA Network Open*, found that anxiety and depression were significantly higher among adults aged 18 to 39 (40% and 33% respectively) compared to adults aged 40 and older, with greater economic precarity among younger adults identified as a contributing factor. According to federal survey data, more than one in three Gen Z young adults aged 18 to 25 met criteria for any mental illness in the past year, equivalent to 12.6 million young people, with anxiety, depression, ADHD, and PTSD as the four most common diagnoses (SAMHSA, 2022). These figures are not merely reflections of greater diagnostic awareness or reduced stigma, though both factors are present. Controlled comparisons with previous generations at equivalent life stages indicate that the generational difference is real and not merely an artifact of reporting patterns.

The COVID-19 pandemic warrants specific mention in this connection, less as an origin than as an accelerator. For an extended period, and at global scale, direct experience was abruptly and massively displaced by its mediated substitute: education, labour, sociality, and intimacy were rerouted through the screen, physical co-presence was suspended, and the use of digital platforms intensified sharply. The pandemic did not create the structural conditions described here; it compressed and universalized them, offering something close to a natural experiment in the mass substitution of first-person experience by its representation. That the sharpest documented increases in anxiety and depression among younger adults coincide with this period

(Collier Villaume et al., 2023) is, on the reading proposed here, not incidental: the pandemic functioned as an intensifier of a tendency already structurally underway, briefly rendering visible, in acute form, a condition that the broader culture produces more gradually and less perceptibly.

Generation Z is not, however, a homogeneous formation. The structural conditions it inherits produce differentiated responses along the axes of class, access, and cultural capital. One segment, those with access to familial patrimony sustained by the resources accumulated by preceding generations, inhabits a condition that recalls, in involuntary form, the figure of the dandy that Boltanski and Chiapello (2005) identify in the nineteenth-century artistic critique: a subject freed from productive necessity yet immersed in the culture of uncertainty, producing nothing except the production of a self. This is not an aesthetic choice but a structural imposition, the coincidence of material comfort and existential precarity that produces a specific form of dissociation: the subject who has the resources to defer reality indefinitely and does so. A second segment, those without such resources, formed in conditions of genuine economic precarity, responds with a different but structurally related movement: the hyper-adhesion to ideologies of success, most legibly expressed in the cultural form of trap music. Trap constitutes an alienation of a compensatory kind: a generation formed in economic exclusion that identifies with the figure of the wealthy trapper, consuming representations of success as a substitute for its structural inaccessibility. This is alienation in the precise Marxian sense: the subject who does not recognize himself in the products of his cultural consumption, but who has no other available mirror. The dissociative subject and the trap-identifying subject are not opposites; they are two responses to the same condition of non-belonging, one retreating into spectatorial distance, the other investing in a compensatory spectacle of success. The cultural politics of this compensatory identification, and its relationship to the broader crisis of symbolic order, warrants separate analysis beyond the scope of this paper.

What Twenge (2017) identifies as the paradox of Generation Z, exposed earlier than any previous cohort to adult stimuli through digital platforms yet delaying the assumption of adult

roles and responsibilities to an unprecedented degree, is, within this framework, not a paradox at all. Early and intense exposure to represented adult experience does not accelerate development: it substitutes for it. The pharmacological dimension of this deferral is equally legible: Generation Z drinks less alcohol and consumes more cannabis than preceding generations, a shift that reflects, within this framework, a generational preference for the dissociative substance over the somatic one. Alcohol implicates the body, produces heightened physical presence even if cognitively distorted. Cannabis produces managed distance, a slowing and softening of the boundary between self and representation that combines naturally with the other technologies of dissociation and potentiates the spectatorial mode.

This generational condition carries a specific developmental significance that differentiates it from comparable phenomena in older cohorts. The years between roughly 12 and 24, the period that encompasses the entirety of Gen Z's formative experience, constitute what developmental psychology identifies as the critical phase of identity formation. Twenge (2017), in his longitudinal analysis of the first generation of true digital natives, documents how intensive immersion in smartphone and social media environments during precisely this phase correlates with measurable disruptions in the psychological markers of healthy adolescent development: reduced autonomy, delayed identity consolidation, and a marked increase in psychological fragility. It is precisely during this phase that Gen Z has been most intensively immersed in an environment organized around fragmentation, performance, and spectatorial distance. The formation of identity under these conditions does not merely produce a different kind of self: it produces a self whose very architecture reflects the logic of the ecosystem in which it was formed: episodic rather than continuous, performative rather than expressive, spectatorial rather than inhabited. Whether this constitutes a permanent structural transformation of subjectivity or a historically contingent adaptation remains an open empirical question, but one that this framework renders, at minimum, theoretically legible.

A further dimension of this deformation concerns the structure of desire itself. The subject formed within the spectatorial ecosystem does not merely defer action: he defers living as such,

postponing the assumption of adult life to a hypothetical future in which conditions will finally be perfect: the right relationship, the right career, the right body, the right circumstances. This infinite deferral is not laziness or immaturity; it is the temporal form of third-person subjectivity. Life is to be lived in the first person only when it will resemble the represented lives that have served as the subject's primary environment. Since those represented lives are simulacra without originals, as Baudrillard's analysis makes clear, the perfect real never arrives. The subject waits. He consumes representations of the life he intends to live, while the living itself never arrives. Turkle's (2011) observation that the connected generation is *alone together*, hyper-present in digital space, deeply isolated in experiential terms, assumes its full theoretical weight here. The paradox he identified has only intensified in the decade since: Gen Z is the most connected generation in history and, by multiple measures, among the loneliest. This is not a contradiction but a logical consequence of the structural substitution traced here: when connectivity replaces belonging, and representation replaces experience, the density of signal does not compensate for the poverty of contact. The dissociative distance that the ecosystem produces is not an effective anesthesia; it is a condition that reproduces, at the psychological level, the very non-belonging that it was recruited to manage.

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6. Alienation Squared: Toward a Theoretical Synthesis

The preceding sections have traced two distinct but causally connected forms of alienation that characterize the condition of the contemporary subject, and Generation Z in particular. This section synthesizes these threads into a unified theoretical framework, one proposed under the rubric of *alienation squared*: a condition of double expropriation in which the structural alienation described by Marx and its successors generates, as its psychological response, a second-order alienation from the self.

The first alienation is historical and structural. It begins with Marx's account of the worker expropriated from the product of his labour and estranged from his own activity, his species-being, and his human community. It passes through the postwar decades of compensatory

security, pension systems, educational credentials, career progression, welfare institutions, in which the promise of belonging was partially redeemed through social rather than patrimonial mechanisms. It arrives, through the post-Fordist transformation of capitalism, at a more intimate form of expropriation: the subject is no longer merely dispossessed of the product of his labour but invited to surrender subjectivity itself, creativity, affect, social relations, personal identity, as productive resources, leaving no stable remainder of interiority outside the demands of the system. And it culminates, through Fisher's concept of capitalist realism, in the cultural foreclosure of imaginative alternatives: a condition in which the existing order presents itself not as contingent but as necessary, and in which the collapse of the spirit of capitalism, its inability to provide convincing answers to its own constitutive questions of enthusiasm, security, and legitimation, produces not revolt but disorientation. Boltanski and Chiapello (2005) identify this disorientation as a crisis of the spirit of capitalism. This paper reads it simultaneously as a crisis of the subject: the ideological collapse of the system and the psychological collapse of the self are not parallel phenomena; they are two registers of the same condition.

The second alienation is the psychological response to this condition, but not in a simple deterministic sense. The relationship between structural conditions and psychological outcomes is non-linear and systemic: the elements co-determine one another without a single identifiable point of origin or a privileged causal direction. What can be identified is a functional logic: faced with a world that offers no stable foothold for selfhood, simultaneously overwhelmed by an unprecedented density of stimuli, and deprived of the symbolic resources through which desire might be constituted and oriented, the contemporary subject develops, consciously or not, adaptively or pathologically, a managed distance from the intensity of direct experience. This distance manifests across a spectrum of responses that are structurally related despite their apparent diversity: the consumption of psychoactive substances, the immersion in digital entertainment, and, at the clinical extreme, the symptomatology described by the DSM-5 as dissociative disorders.

It is here that the central theoretical contribution of this paper is introduced: the concept of *third-person subjectivity* as the dominant mode of selfhood produced by the intersection of spectacular culture, digital capitalism, and second-order alienation. Third-person subjectivity is defined as a structural mode of self-relation in which the subject is habitually and increasingly constitutively positioned as spectator of his own experience rather than as its agent and first-person inhabitant, a mode that exists on a continuum from the culturally normalized to the clinically pathological, and that is actively produced and sustained by the ecosystem of contemporary digital capitalism. The concept finds its most acute clinical expression in depersonalization disorder, recognized by the DSM-5 as a condition in which the subject observes himself from the outside, experiencing his own thoughts, feelings, and actions as belonging to someone else. Depersonalization disorder is proposed here as the symbolic illness of our epoch: not because it is the most statistically prevalent psychiatric condition, but because its structure, the self displaced from its own experience, watching rather than inhabiting, is the pathological intensification of a mode of being that the broader culture actively produces and normalizes. The clinical and the cultural exist on a continuum; what the DSM-5 identifies at the pathological extreme is, at its subclinical base, the dominant experiential mode of a generation formed within spectacular, hyperreal, and dissociation-inducing conditions.

The concept of third-person subjectivity unifies, under a single structural description, phenomena that have typically been treated in isolation. At the level of cultural consumption: serialized television, gaming, social media self-presentation, pornography, reaction content, all share the organizing principle of positioning the subject as spectator rather than agent of experience. Pornography is sex in the third person. Reaction content is emotion in the third person. Social media self-presentation is identity in the third person, the subject observing and curating his own image as if from the outside. At the pharmacological level: cannabis, the elective substance of Generation Z, produces precisely the managed distance that characterizes third-person subjectivity, a softening of the boundary between self and representation that potentiates rather than disrupts the spectatorial mode. At the temporal level: the infinite deferral of living, the

postponement of adult life, of intimate commitment, of vocational engagement, to a hypothetical future in which conditions will finally be perfect, is the chronological form of third-person subjectivity. The subject does not merely observe his present experience from a distance; he suspends his life itself, waiting to inhabit it in the first person only when it will resemble the represented lives that have constituted his primary environment. Since those represented lives are simulacra without originals, the perfect real never arrives. At the clinical level: depersonalization disorder represents the pathological terminus of this continuum, the point at which the spectatorial distance becomes total, involuntary, and ego-dystonic.

A further dimension of this framework concerns the collapse of symbolic orientation and its consequences for desire. Lacan's account of the relationship between Law and desire, whatever its normative implications, offers a useful descriptive lens here: historically, desire has constituted itself through a symbolic structure, a set of prohibitions and limits that gave it orientation and direction. The transgressive culture that Boltanski and Chiapello (2005) identify in the artistic critique of the 1960s and 1970s operated precisely within such a structure: the bourgeois Law existed, and transgression defined itself against it, deriving its energy and meaning from the limit it crossed. What characterizes the contemporary condition is not the presence of transgression but the absence of a stable symbolic structure against which desire might orient itself. The result is not liberation but disorientation: a subject who cannot find stable direction for desire because the symbolic coordinates that historically provided it have eroded. This is legible in the polarized cultural responses observable among segments of Generation Z: the adhesion to rigid ideological formations, from identity-based prescriptivism to authoritarian nationalist movements, from hyper-masculine online subcultures to moralistic progressivism, represents, in this reading, not political conviction in any robust sense but a search for external structures of orientation in the absence of shared symbolic coordinates. The subject reaches for an imposed limit precisely because the internal symbolic structure that would generate orientation organically has been eroded.

Before proceeding to the final synthesis, it is necessary to address three objections that the framework developed here is likely to attract.

The first is the charge of *sociologizing the clinic*: that this paper deploys clinical categories, dissociation, depersonalization, third-person subjectivity, outside their proper domain, stretching their meaning beyond what clinical evidence supports. This objection would be well-founded if the argument were claiming that cultural conditions *cause* dissociative disorders in a direct and measurable sense. It is not. The claim is more precise: that the structure of third-person subjectivity, the habitual positioning of the subject as spectator of his own experience, is observable across a continuum that runs from culturally normalized modes of engagement to clinically diagnosable conditions, and that this continuum is not merely analogical but structural: the cultural and the clinical are not separate domains connected by resemblance, but points on a single spectrum produced by the same underlying processes. The rising prevalence of the clinical condition is therefore legible as a signal of the broader structural tendency. This is not a category error: it is the kind of claim that the sociology of mental health, from Durkheim onward, has made with increasing methodological precision.

The second objection is the inverse: that this paper *pathologizes culture,* that by reading contemporary entertainment, digital life, and pharmacological preference through the lens of dissociation, it implicitly treats modernity as a disease and its subjects as patients. This reading would misunderstand the direction of the argument. The claim is not that contemporary culture is pathological in any normative sense, but that it produces, as an emergent property of structural conditions rather than as a design, a mode of subjectivity that shares its architecture with what clinical nosology identifies, at the extreme end of a continuum, as disorder. The pathology is not in the culture; it is in the structural conditions that generate both the cultural forms and the clinical outcomes. To name this is not to pathologize: it is to trace a structural logic that connects phenomena ordinarily kept separate.

The third objection concerns the direction of causality: perhaps the relationship between dissociative tendencies and the consumption of dissociative technologies is not that the latter

produces the former, but that subjects who are constitutionally or developmentally predisposed to dissociation are selectively attracted to environments that facilitate it. This is a legitimate empirical question, and one that the current state of research cannot fully resolve. The framework advanced here does not depend on resolving it. As argued in Section 4, the relationship between structural conditions and psychological outcomes is non-linear and systemic, a field of mutual co-determination in which the direction of causality is neither singular nor unidirectional. A subject predisposed to dissociation who inhabits an ecosystem designed to facilitate spectatorial distance will have that predisposition amplified and normalized; a subject without such predisposition who inhabits the same ecosystem for sufficient duration and intensity will have the threshold for dissociative responses systematically lowered. In both cases, the structural conditions are causally relevant. The objection identifies a real complexity without undermining the core claim.

The relationship between the two alienations can now be stated with full precision. The first alienation, structural and historical, produces a subject who does not belong: to his labour, to the institutions that organize his life, to any collective horizon of meaning or action, and to the symbolic order through which desire might be constituted. The second alienation, psychological, cultural, and temporal, is this subject's response: a retreat from the uninhabitable first person into the managed distance of the third. This retreat is not freely chosen; it is functionally demanded by a systemic configuration of which market logic is one significant but not exhaustive component, a broader assemblage of technological affordances, cultural forms, social expectations, and economic incentives that converges, as an emergent property rather than a coordinated design, on the systematic minimization of the demands of unmediated experience. Entertainment is easier than life. The spectatorial position is less exposed than the agentive one. The represented life is more perfect than the lived one. And so the subject, overwhelmed, unbelonging, and symbolically unmoored, migrates, gradually, habitually, and increasingly without awareness, from the first person to the third.

This is alienation squared: not the addition of one alienation to another, but their mutual reinforcement in a dynamic that resists simple linear description. The structurally alienated subject seeks relief in the technologies of dissociation; habitual immersion in those technologies deepens his distance from first-person experience; that distance makes direct engagement with the structural world, with its demands for presence, continuity, and agentive selfhood, feel increasingly unmanageable; the collapse of the symbolic order removes the structural support through which desire might orient that engagement; and the retreat into third-person subjectivity intensifies accordingly. The loop does not have a correctable origin point. It is a systemic condition, one that requires, for its analysis, exactly the kind of framework this paper has attempted to construct: one that holds together the structural and the psychological, the historical and the clinical, the philosophical and the empirical, the economic and the symbolic, without reducing any of these dimensions to the others.

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7. Conclusion: Toward a Structural Reading of Psychological Suffering

This paper has proposed a theoretical framework for understanding a condition that clinical literature documents but does not fully explain: the rising prevalence of dissociative phenomena among the generations born into digital capitalism. The argument has moved through several connected claims. Beginning with the Marxian account of alienation as structural dispossession, the subject expropriated from the product of his labour, his activity, his species-being, and his human community, it has traced its evolution through the postwar compensatory apparatus, its post-Fordist erosion, and the cultural foreclosure described by Fisher as capitalist realism. It then traced the passage, through Debord and Baudrillard, from structural alienation to spectacular and hyperreal culture, a world in which lived experience is systematically substituted by representation, and in which the dominant cultural forms converge on a single organizing principle: the positioning of the subject as spectator rather than agent of experience. Drawing on Wallace, entertainment in its contemporary form is read as anesthesia, another way of not living, and the contemporary entertainment ecosystem and its associated psychoactive substances is

understood as a set of technologies of dissociation through which the subject actively, if not always consciously, seeks relief from the demands of direct experience.

The theoretical contribution proposed in response to these convergent pressures is the concept of *third-person subjectivity*: a mode of self-relation in which the subject is positioned, structurally, habitually, and in its most acute clinical manifestations pathologically, as observer of his own experience rather than as its inhabitant. This concept unifies, under a single structural description, phenomena that are typically treated in isolation: the clinical symptomatology of depersonalization disorder, the cultural forms of the entertainment ecosystem, the pharmacological preferences of a generation, the temporal structure of infinite deferral, and the technological logic of AI-generated hyperreality. The dissociated subject and the binge-watching subject and the drug-tripping subject and the infinitely deferring subject share a common architecture, a retreat from first-person experience into the managed distance of the third, and that architecture is not accidental but structurally produced by the intersection of economic alienation, spectacular culture, and the collapse of the symbolic order.

The clinical implications of this framework are significant, though they require development beyond the scope of this paper. If dissociation in its rising subclinical prevalence is understood as a structural response rather than a purely individual pathology, then clinical intervention oriented exclusively toward the individual, toward symptom reduction and cognitive restructuring, addresses only one dimension of a phenomenon that has a structural dimension equally in need of attention. This does not diminish the importance of clinical treatment; it complicates its frame. The subject who seeks anesthetic distance from his own experience is not merely dysregulated: he is responding, with a degree of functional logic, to conditions that make first-person inhabitation of existence genuinely difficult. Understanding those conditions is a prerequisite for addressing their consequences.

The political implications are equally significant. If third-person subjectivity is the dominant mode of selfhood produced by digital capitalism, then the political subject that this formation produces is one who observes rather than acts, who consumes representations of political life

rather than participating in it, who maintains the ironic distance that Wallace identified as the cultural habitus of the entertained generation, and who, when the demand for symbolic orientation becomes unbearable, reaches for external ideological formations that promise to restore structure from the outside. This is not merely a cultural observation; it is a diagnosis of the structural conditions of political agency and symbolic life under contemporary capitalism. What this paper has attempted, finally, is to demonstrate that the categories of philosophy, sociology, and clinical psychology are not merely adjacent but mutually illuminating: that the structure of a psychiatric symptom can be read as the concentrated expression of a cultural, economic, and symbolic condition, and that cultural analysis gains in precision and urgency when it is held accountable to the specificity of psychological suffering. The subject who does not belong to the world, and who has therefore retreated from himself, is not an abstraction. He is the paradigmatic figure of our historical moment. Understanding his condition, in its full structural depth, is among the most urgent tasks the human sciences currently face.

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